

Counterpoint

The term “counterpoint” comes from the Latin *contra punctus contra*, or point-against-point. Musical counterpoint emphasizes individual musical lines—these independently structured parts interact to create a fuller harmonic texture.

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Partner songs

Simple counterpoint results when two unique songs with similar harmonic structure and complementary melodies are sung or played together. These tunes stand on their own as unique pieces, but are also performed as “partner songs”—the two independent lines create a polyphonic, contrapuntal effect.

▽ “Hey ho”/“Ah poor bird”

In counterpoint, the combination of two or more familiar folk tunes, like these two old English rounds, is also called a *quodlibet*.

Song 1

Ah, poor bird, take your flight.

Song 2

Hey, ho, no - bo - dy home. Meat, nor, drink, nor mon - ey, have I none.

Up a - bove the sor - row of this dark night.

Yet will I be mer - ry. Hey, ho, ho.

Rounds

A tune composed to allow two or more voices to sing or play the exact same melody beginning at different intervals of time is called a round, or canon. Rounds are composed to be repeated multiple times, unlike canons, which have definite endings.

▷ “Frère Jacques”

This French nursery rhyme (called “Brother John” or “Are You Sleeping?” in English) is one of the world’s best-known rounds.

Frère - re Jac - ques, Dor - mez - vous? Son - nez les ma - ti - nes, Ding, daing, dong!

Frère - re Jac - ques, Dor - mez - vous? Son - nez les ma - ti - nes,

Frère - re Jac - ques, Dor - mez - vous?

Frère - re Jac - ques,